

Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics

Privacy Configuration Guide

Privacy thresholds, exclusion lists, data residency & compliance controls

Document Property	Value
Section	Setup
Audience	IT Admin / Governance
Version	4.2
Last validated	2 October 2026

Choose the Action by Intended Outcome

Policy goal	Use this exact action	Expected user result	Validation
Keep sensitive typed prompt text away from external web search, while allowing an answer from permitted internal Microsoft 365 data	Prevent Copilot from processing content > Performing Web Searches	External web search is blocked as a grounding source. Copilot can still return an internally grounded response.	Use a synthetic sensitive-information-type value. Confirm the response has no web grounding and can still use an accessible internal test document.
Prevent Copilot from processing or answering a typed prompt that contains a selected sensitive information type	Prevent Copilot from processing content > Processing prompts (preview)	Copilot returns no answer and does not use the prompt for internal or web searches.	First confirm the preview has reached the tenant. Test a benign prompt and a synthetic matching prompt in each required app; capture policy simulation/alert evidence and the user result.

Prevent selected labeled files or emails from contributing content to a response	Content contains > Sensitivity labels with Prevent Copilot from processing content	Matching content is not processed for the response summary, although the item can still appear as a citation.	Use labeled and unlabeled test items accessible to the same test identity. Confirm content use and citation behavior separately.
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Worked example: block web grounding without blocking the full response

Contoso wants prompts containing a synthetic customer identifier to remain inside Microsoft 365 but still allow employees to use internal documents. The DLP rule uses the **Performing Web Searches** action. A matching test prompt should still be able to answer from a permitted internal test file, but it must not use external web search. If the requirement is instead “return no response at all,” this is the wrong action; use the preview **Processing prompts** action and validate rollout first.

How This Document Fits

This is a **Setup** guide. It covers the privacy and compliance settings that govern how Copilot Analytics data is collected, stored, and displayed. Configure these settings *before* enabling dashboards or running queries.

Section	Purpose	Who Reads
Strategy	Decide what to implement	CIO, SA, Business Leaders
Setup (you are here)	Configure and deploy	IT Admin, Insights Admin
Operate	Use dashboards and reports daily	Leaders, Analysts, Managers
Reference	Look up details and fix issues	Everyone (as needed)

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1. Privacy Thresholds

Privacy thresholds protect **aggregated organization insights**; they do not turn every Viva Insights output into aggregate-only data. Insights Analysts can receive de-identified row-level employee records in advanced analysis, and uploaded organizational attributes can make a person inferable when combined. Identification, a separate capability, lets authorised users see named employees (“identified outputs”) in Consumption Dashboard insights and exports and in the Copilot Dashboard and Agent Dashboard data exports (listed as private preview; Microsoft’s Agent Dashboard export article says public preview, so validate in the tenant).

Setting	Default	Configurable Range
Minimum group size	10 users	5–unlimited (lowest allowed = 5)

How Thresholds Work

- **Data suppression:** Results for groups below the threshold are not shown, so potentially identifiable information is not displayed.
- **Dashboard and manager/leader insights:** These surfaces use protected aggregates, minimum group size, distribution masking, and differential privacy where documented.
- **Advanced analysis:** An Insights Analyst can query de-identified individual-level organizational and Microsoft 365 metrics. The encrypted person identifier is not a guarantee of anonymity if title, location, organization, or custom attributes enable inference.
- **Access governance:** Treat analyst output as potentially personal data. Use least-privilege partitions, require role-specific privacy/security training, define an approved analysis purpose, and audit authored queries against policy and any data protection impact assessment.
- **Identification:** Copilot Analytics outputs are de-identified by default. Identification lets authorised users see named employees (“identified outputs”). Microsoft lists it for Consumption Dashboard insights and data export, and lists Copilot Dashboard and Agent Dashboard data exports as private preview. For the Agent Dashboard export, Microsoft’s articles disagree: Identification says private preview, while Export data from the Agent Dashboard says identifiable export “is for public preview customers only”; validate in the tenant. Access is governed by a dedicated Viva feature access management (VFAM) policy, which only a Microsoft 365 Global Administrator or an AI Administrator can create. When identifiable export is enabled for a user, their export includes identifiable fields; otherwise, personal identifiers are replaced with anonymised IDs.
- **GitHub page opt-in (public preview):** Privacy settings in the Viva Insights web app also hold the opt-in for the Consumption Dashboard GitHub page. Microsoft states that this preview feature allows personal data processing.

Sources: Advanced analysis privacy — Personal data, de-identified data, and calculated data (Microsoft Learn, updated 10 December 2025) documents de-identified row-level output and re-identification risk; Roles in Viva Insights — Levels of responsibility (7 July 2026) distinguishes analyst row-level access; and Advanced analysis privacy — Advanced analysis access (10 December 2025) recommends training and states that analyst-authored queries are logged for audit.

Minimum Team Size vs Minimum Group Size — They Are Different

These two settings apply in different contexts and are configured in different places. Both have a minimum of 5.

Setting	Where Configured	What It Controls	Who It Counts
Minimum team size	Viva Insights → Admin → Manager settings	Manager-facing insights (My Team tab, Copilot Dashboard manager view)	Includes the manager in the headcount
Minimum group size	Viva Insights → Admin → Privacy settings	Copilot Dashboard aggregated views, Power BI query results	Counts people in the group; Microsoft does not say whether the viewer is included

Example: If both are set to 5, a manager with exactly 4 direct reports will see their team data (4 reports + 1 manager = 5, meeting the team size threshold), but an analyst filtering a dashboard to a group of 4 users will see suppressed data (4 < 5, below the group size threshold).

2. Exclusion Lists

The unified exclusion list is a **reporting control**, not a universal statement that data is never collected or processed. It tells the documented Dashboard and Viva reporting surfaces not to show specified users in their aggregates.

What Gets Excluded

- Microsoft Copilot Dashboard, Agent Dashboard and Consumption Dashboard aggregated insights
- Viva Insights behavioral collaboration reports in advanced analysis
- Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat (web) usage in the Copilot Dashboard, including a Microsoft 365 licensed user who does not have a Copilot or Viva Insights license

Microsoft Learn does **not** describe this list as deleting source data or excluding a person from every query type and processing path. For exclusion from advanced-analysis processing, manage the user’s Viva Insights service plan as part of the data-subject-request workflow below.

Not the Adoption Score opt-out

The unified exclusion list is separate from the Adoption Score People experience opt-out. Microsoft states that when you opt out specific user groups from calculating People experience insights in Adoption Score, the AI adoption category doesn’t respect that opt-out in the current release. See AI adoption category in Adoption Score.

How to Upload

Method	Steps
CSV upload	Prepare a CSV with user email addresses → Microsoft 365 admin center → Microsoft Viva → Viva Insights → Set up and management → unified exclusion list. Confirm the current labels in the tenant UI.
Microsoft Entra groups	Create or select an Entra group containing users to exclude, then configure the unified exclusion list through the current Microsoft 365 admin center workflow.

Processing Times

Action	Time to Take Effect
Exclusion list changes	Microsoft states: "After you remove users with an exclusion list, it will take up to three days for the changes to take effect." Verify the resulting membership and report behaviour in the tenant after that window.

Plan Exclusions Before Dashboard Launch

Because Microsoft says exclusion-list changes can take up to three days to take effect, configure and verify the list before launch. Confirm the policy is on, inspect the resulting membership, and test the affected reports after that window.

Source: Manage settings for the Microsoft Copilot Dashboard, Agent Dashboard, and Viva Insights web app — unified exclusion list (Microsoft Learn, updated 13 August 2026).

3. Data Residency

Microsoft documents local data-at-rest behavior for **Viva Insights advanced analysis, manager, and leader collaboration activities and metric computations**. The location is determined by the tenant’s default geography (default mailbox region), not by each user’s location. It is not a universal statement about every Copilot Analytics workload.

Viva Insights provisioned after	Tenant default mailbox region	Advanced, manager, and leader data stored at rest in
4 June 2024	Australia (AUS)	Australia
12 August 2024	Japan (JPN)	Japan
13 September 2024	Canada (CA)	Canada
13 September 2024	United Kingdom (GB)	United Kingdom

Customers provisioned before the applicable date continue to be hosted in the region used before local residency became available. Use Microsoft’s static workload–location table for that case rather than inferring location from the current tenant geography.

Verification Steps

1. Record the tenant default mailbox region and the date Viva Insights was provisioned.
2. Apply the matrix above. For earlier provisioning, consult the linked static workload–location information.
3. If either value is unavailable or the result is material to a residency attestation, obtain tenant–specific confirmation through Microsoft Support; do not infer it from a user mailbox or a generic tenant–region label.
4. Have legal/compliance approve the documented workload scope and evidence before making a sovereignty statement.

Source: Viva Insights data residency for advanced analysis, managers, and leaders (Microsoft Learn, updated 17 September 2026), including its link to static data location information for select services.

3B. Microsoft Purview DLP for Copilot Prompts

Microsoft Purview Data Loss Prevention (DLP) uses the **Microsoft 365 Copilot and Copilot Chat** policy location. The actions below have different effects and must not be described as one generic prompt block.

Conditions, Actions, and Status

Condition and exact action	Status	Documented result
Content contains > Sensitive information types Prevent Copilot from processing content > Performing Web Searches	Supported action; the article does not label this action preview	Blocks external web search as a grounding source. Copilot can still respond using permitted internal Microsoft 365 data.
Content contains > Sensitive information types Prevent Copilot from processing content > Processing prompts	Preview; rolling out to tenants	Copilot does not respond, and the prompt is not used for internal or web searches. Check whether rollout has reached the tenant. Available in Microsoft 365 Copilot, Copilot Chat, and Copilot in Word, Excel and PowerPoint.
Content contains > Sensitivity labels Prevent Copilot from processing content	Supported; the article does not label this action preview	Selected labeled files and emails are not processed or used in the response summary, although an item can still appear in citations. Calendar invites are unsupported; documented email coverage starts 1 January 2025.
Email is received from > External users Prevent Copilot from processing content	Preview	Emails from senders outside the organisation's accepted domains are excluded from grounding, summarisation and citation in Microsoft 365 Copilot and Copilot Chat. Only the sender domain is evaluated, not the email body, and the user's own access to the email is unchanged.

Prompt SIT Blocking Is Preview

Do not treat **Processing prompts** as a guaranteed production boundary until the tenant exposes the preview control and a positive/negative test confirms enforcement. During preview, Word, Excel, and PowerPoint messaging might not clearly identify organizational policy as the reason for the block.

Important Limitations

- DLP evaluates text typed directly into a prompt; it cannot scan the contents of files uploaded directly in prompts.
- Sensitive-information-type and sensitivity-label conditions cannot be combined in the same rule, although separate rules can be placed in one policy.
- The location is available only in a **Custom** policy template; DLP alerts, notifications, and simulation mode are supported.
- Policy updates can take up to four hours to appear in Copilot experiences.

Why This Matters for Analytics Teams

- **Analytics-count impact is not verifiable from Microsoft Learn.** The DLP article documents response and search behavior, but does not state whether a blocked attempt is logged or counted in Copilot Analytics.
- Do not use DLP as an explanation for adoption gaps without a controlled tenant test or Microsoft Support confirmation that covers the specific report and metric.
- Coordinate Security/Compliance and Analytics teams so policy tests, dates, affected users, and observed report behavior are recorded together.

Validate the Unknown Analytics-Count Impact

Microsoft Learn does not document whether a DLP-blocked attempt appears in each Copilot Analytics metric. Do not infer the answer from the DLP alert or from one dashboard total. Use this controlled protocol when the distinction is operationally material:

1. **Approve the test:** use a non-production or approved pilot cohort, synthetic values only, one documented DLP policy/action, and a fixed UTC test window.
2. **Establish controls:** from the same app and test identity, submit a benign prompt that should succeed and a synthetic matching prompt that should be restricted. Record exact timestamps and expected outcomes.
3. **Prove policy behavior:** retain the DLP simulation/alert record and the observed Copilot response for both prompts. This proves enforcement, not analytics counting.

4. **Wait for each report's documented latency:** inspect the relevant Copilot Dashboard metric, admin-center report, export, or advanced query using the same population and time boundary. Do not compare different report windows.
5. **Record the result as tenant-specific:** document whether the successful and blocked attempts can be distinguished, the report/metric/version, policy action, latency, and any ambiguity.
6. **Escalate ambiguity:** if the result affects adoption reporting or a customer statement, open Microsoft Support with policy, timestamps, alert IDs, report/export evidence, expected behavior, and observed behavior. Until confirmed, retain the wording **Not verifiable from Microsoft Learn**.

Configuration Reference

DLP for Copilot is configured in the **Microsoft Purview portal**, not in Viva Insights. **Source:** Microsoft Purview DLP for Microsoft 365 Copilot and Copilot Chat (Microsoft Learn, updated 17 September 2026).

Complementary to Analytics

DLP for Copilot and Copilot Analytics serve different purposes but are part of the same deployment posture. A well-governed Copilot deployment uses **DLP** to prevent sensitive data exposure, **Copilot Analytics** to measure adoption and impact, and **Organisational Messages** to drive enablement. Consider establishing a cross-functional team that includes Security (Purview), IT (Admin Centre), and Analytics (Viva Insights) stakeholders.

4. GDPR and Regional Compliance

Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics is designed with GDPR compliance in mind. The following controls support regulatory requirements:

- **End-user opt-out:** When enabled, this removes the user’s behavioral metrics from future row-level outputs. It does not apply to aggregated organization insights, meeting-query results, or row-level Copilot usage data.
- **Data minimisation:** Dashboards and manager/leader insights use protected aggregates; advanced-analysis queries can contain de-identified individual rows; identified outputs, where an administrator enables Identification, can name employees. Limit attributes, rows, retention, and query purpose to what the approved analysis requires.
- **Org data handling:** If you upload organisational data (CSV with attributes like Department, Agency, Location), ensure the upload process follows your organisation’s data handling policies. Do not include sensitive personal data in org data attributes.

Data Subject Request Control Path

Request	Accountable action
Validate and own the request	The organization is the data controller. Legal/privacy evaluates validity, scope, identity, jurisdiction, and required response; Microsoft acts as data processor.
Exclude from advanced-analysis processing	Do not assign, or remove, the user’s Viva Insights service plan. Microsoft notes that removing the service plan removes the person and collaboration data from the measured population for advanced analysis and organization insights, but does not remove the person from the Copilot Dashboard measured population.
Exclude from Copilot Dashboard aggregates	Use and verify the unified exclusion list described in Section 2.
Access	Use the Viva Insights export mechanism for raw, personally associable data within the validated request scope; aggregate metrics from which no personal data can be gleaned are outside that export scope.
Correction	Correct the source system: Microsoft 365 email/calendar data or the uploaded organizational-data source. Viva Insights does not correct source data itself.

Deletion

Use the Microsoft 365 GDPR Right to erasure process as applicable; delete reports that identify the subject and remove the subject from organizational or other customer-provided datasets where required.

Evidence and closure

Record approvals, controls changed, timestamps, export/delete evidence, affected reports, and post-change verification. Escalate to Microsoft Support if the required control or data cannot be located.

Source: Advanced analysis privacy — Managing data subject requests and Remove employees from the measured population (Microsoft Learn, updated 10 December 2025); end-user opt-out scope is documented in Customize Viva Insights privacy settings (20 November 2025).

Regional Considerations

Some regions may have additional requirements beyond GDPR (e.g., UK-GDPR, Australia Privacy Act). Work with your legal and compliance teams to confirm that your privacy threshold settings, exclusion lists, and org data handling meet local regulations.

5. Data Retention

Retention of backend Viva Insights data is different from a dashboard display window or an export range. Do not use one as proof of the other.

Data Source	Retention Period	Notes
Advanced Analytics — Collaboration metrics	Initially 13 months ; grows weekly to a maximum of 27 months	No collaboration data older than 27 months is retained.
Advanced Analytics — Copilot metrics	Maximum 13 months	Microsoft 365 Copilot metrics do not grow to the 27-month collaboration window.
Dashboard views, dashboard export, and Microsoft 365 admin usage reports	Separate feature-specific windows	Use the current documentation for the specific surface; these windows do not redefine the 27/13-month Viva Insights retention policy.

Govern Long-Term Snapshots Separately

If you retain exported or Power BI snapshots beyond a product’s interactive window, apply an approved business purpose, access controls, retention schedule, and deletion process. A local snapshot is a new governed copy.

Source: Advanced analysis privacy — Retaining sensitive data (Microsoft Learn, updated 10 December 2025).

6. Supported Environments

Feature	Worldwide	GCC Moderate	GCC High
Manage privacy settings	Yes	Yes	Yes
Unified exclusion list for Copilot Dashboard	Yes (Manage settings article)	Not listed in the matrix	Not listed in the matrix; the VFAM article says its access controls are unavailable in GCC High and DoD
Custom advanced-analysis queries	Yes	Yes (person, meeting and cross-collaboration queries)	Yes (same queries); the Consumption query is Worldwide only
Copilot Power BI reports	Yes (latest usage snapshot and headlines reports are Public Preview)	Copilot business impact report only; the other Copilot templates are unavailable	Copilot business impact report (partial); the other Copilot templates are unavailable
Behavioral Power BI reports	Yes	All except the Skills landscape report	Supported: Business resilience, Impact explorer, Meeting effectiveness, Recurring meeting audit, Ways of working, and Wellbeing – Balance and flexibility. Partial: Growth, inclusion and engagement, Hybrid workforce experience, Manager effectiveness, and Onboarding and development. Unavailable: Change management, Learning culture and Skills landscape
Agent Dashboard / Copilot metrics export	Copilot Agent view and exports: Public Preview. Agent 365 view: Yes	No	No

The current Microsoft matrix covers Worldwide, GCC Moderate and GCC High. DoD is not covered: do not infer DoD feature parity from plan-level support, and validate the exact cloud, Message Center, and tenant UI before committing to a control or report. **Source:** Supported Microsoft 365 environments for Viva Insights features (Microsoft Learn, updated 30 September 2026).

7. What to Read Next

Document	When to Use
Admin Setup Guide	Configure the current Copilot Analytics areas — roles, licences, VFAM, org data, manager settings, and partitions
Troubleshooting Guide	Fix common issues: missing data, dashboard not appearing, suppressed metrics
Data Onboarding Guide	Upload and validate organisational data (CSV attributes, Entra sync)
Dashboard Guide	Understand each dashboard page and how to interpret the metrics

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